Case Study 1 - Atari

Student submission

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Worksheet link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/bf32

Grading link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/bf32

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 0 declared AI use; 1 declared no AI use; policy v1

Game Overview

Game details

Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

Submitted response

The game I picked was Frankenstein monster. It was released in 1983, the developer is Data Age and the original publisher was Atari. It’s a platform game and the version I played was the Atari 2600 rom version online.

History and industry

Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

Submitted response

When the game Frankenstein's monster was released at the time the Atari 2600 was a well established important gaming platform. The game mainly used horror elements based on Mary Shelley's 1818 novel Frankenstein. The company that made it was called Data Age and during this time it was struggling, they struggled so much that eventually in April 1983 they filed for bankruptcy, so it gave the game a more difficult release.

Contemporary comparison

Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

Submitted response

A game I would like to compare it to is Halloween. Both were released for the Atari 2600 in 1983. In Halloween, the player rescues children while avoiding a killer inside a house. Both games require players to navigate through danger while trying to complete an objective, but their main challenges are different. Frankenstein’s Monster focuses on platforming, jumping over obstacles, while Halloween focuses on escaping the killer and bringing children to safety.

Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Core gameplay mechanics

Response prompt

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

Submitted response

The core actions are you moving and jumping around avoiding enemies in six round trips to gather bricks to build a protective wall around the monster. The player has to decide whether to move quickly to save time or slow down to

avoid losing. For example, when approaching a pit or spider, jumping at the wrong moment can cause you to completely have to start from the beginning or lose a life (“Frankenstein’s Monster,” Wikipedia).

Level design

Response prompt

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The layout is in Frankenstein’s castle that is split into three main tiers for each section, there are enemies that move and guard each section, also there are traps like pits and trapdoors. Running out of time triggers an instant game over, so the player is batting not only enemies but time as well.

Graphic And Audio Design

Visual design

Response prompt

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

I think the visual design choice that keeps the player on their toes is that, when the timer expires, the monster breaks free and walks directly toward the screen and that makes it feel more defeating.

Sound design

Response prompt

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The game’s sound effects are very jarring at first because it’s too many sounds happening at once, you got the player’s jump noise, steps, climbing noise, and danger noises just to name a few. I would say that sounds of damage taken is meant to not just make the player know they are hurt but meant to build suspense, and because the Atari 2600 had limited sounds, the audio is more crunchy than modern sounds. The horror theme also makes the sound useful for creating tension.

Narrative And Storytelling

Narrative and setting

Response prompt

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

Submitted response

The setting of the game is in a castle, it’s Frankenstein’s castle. The story is: The player in the castle is going through all levels to collect bricks and build a wall around Frankenstein’s monster before it comes alive and the player must avoid obstacles and finish the wall before time runs out.

Character development

Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

Submitted response

Frankenstein’s Monster has very little character development because the game focuses more on the action than

storytelling. The only important parts are your character and navigation through the castle avoiding things, and the character doesn't really have much design or personality. The only thing you can say in “development” is just winning the game but that depends more on the player than the character.

Impact And Reception

Reception

Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback.
Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

Submitted response

Frankenstein’s Monster received mostly positive feedback both at the time of its release and later. In a later review from 2017, Adam Wallace of “Defunct Games” called it “one of the best looking and sounding games in the whole Atari 2600 library”; he went on to talk about the graphics and animations. “The Video Game Critic” also gave the game a B minus in 2010, calling it “a hidden gem.” Overall, it seems like throughout time people became more positive about the game as a whole, as you can see it seems that for a game at that time looking back it’s very good.

Industry and cultural impact

Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

Submitted response

Frankenstein’s Monster is significant because it shows how the developers had a vision for this game, even if it’s kind of bare-bones in a way, you can still understand what you’re playing and what the game is about. There is not enough evidence that it directly influenced later games, but its significance is an example of how developers adapted horror stories into games when branching off of books or shows.

Reflection

Fun and experience

Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

Submitted response

The most frustrating part of the game was the timing aspects of the jump mechanics. It took many failures to realize how hard it is to time jumps in this game. Sometimes I would jump like not even close to a pit and still manage to fall in somehow. But I think that it's enjoyable when you get the hang of it because it's kind of addicting to avoid the obstacles in the way, and I think the repetition is easy to understand. It's an old platformer, so little annoyances are expected, but overall I thought the game for its time is very fun.

Learning and research

Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

Submitted response

This case study taught me that when it comes to older games, it’s hard to find sources that are not only reliable but also very informed because sometimes the limited aspects of the game can make reviews very limited. I found Wikipedia useful for basic facts, but looking at older reviews and later reviews from sites like “Defunct Games” and “The Video Game Critic” helped me understand how opinions of the game changed over time.